while the two regiments with R-14s and one with R-12s, located farther away from European targets, would be shipped to Cuba. Statsenko was to be “compensated” for the R-12 regiment he would leave in Ukraine with two other R-12 regiments transferred from northern Ukraine and Lithuania. The newly formed unit under Statsenko’s command would be renamed the 51st Missile Division. In Cuba it would become known as “the Statsenko outfit” after its commander.[8]

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THE SIXTY-YEAR-OLD COLONEL GENERAL ISSA PLIEV BECAME the commander of the Group of Soviet Troops in Cuba—the official name of the task force—on July 7. This last-minute appointment to the most important and sensitive position in the whole operation came as a surprise to many, most notably Pliev himself. As the main objective of Operation Anadyr was placing missiles in Cuba, it had been assumed that a senior officer from the Strategic Missile Forces would be selected to lead the mission. Many expected the position of commander in chief to go to the forty-three-year-old Lieutenant General Pavel Dankevich, the commander of the 43rd Missile Army and Statsenko’s direct superior. Four of the five missile regiments that would comprise Statsenko’s division in Cuba came from Dankevich’s army.

But Khrushchev decided on a different commander and personally requested Dankevich not to take offense. General Garbuz and others who expected Dankevich to become the supreme commander in Cuba explained the bypassing of Dankevich by the need for secrecy: the appointment of a commander of a missile army as head of the Cuban contingent would give away the main purpose of the operation—installing ballistic missiles on the island. General Garbuz suggested also another interpretation: “We realized that Khrushchev chose a different commander because he knew that there could be some critical moments during the deployment of detachments, when it would be necessary to stand up for ourselves, to defend the right to deploy missiles there.”[9]